Lesson 41: Word Forms

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 4: Words, Word Order and the Essay

Adapted from Building Academic Writing Skills by Lin Cui, Harper College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): Unit 18 Word Forms.

In this lesson

You learn to recognize nouns, verbs, adjectives and adverbs by their position in a sentence and by their suffixes (endings such as -tion, -ful and -ly). You practise -ed and -ing adjectives and the word forms used in comparisons, with texts about social media, phones and family life. Choosing the right form (success, succeed, successful, successfully) makes your academic sentences correct and clear.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Name the usual positions of nouns, verbs, adjectives and adverbs in a sentence.
- Use common suffixes to recognize the part of speech of a word.
- Choose between -ed adjectives (feelings) and -ing adjectives (the cause of the feelings).
- Make comparisons with "the same … as", "as … as", -er / more … than and the -est / the most.
- Find and correct word form errors in a paragraph.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
part of speech	the job of a word in a sentence: noun, verb, adjective or adverb	"Success" is a noun; "succeed" is a verb.
word form	the form a word takes for each part of speech	success, succeed, successful, successfully
word family	words from the same base with different suffixes	care, careful, carefully, careless
suffix	something such as "ly" or "er" added to the end of a word	-tion, -ment, -ful, -ly
linking verb	a verb such as "be" or "grow" that links the subject to an adjective	Instagram has grown **popular**.
comparative	the form for comparing two: -er / more … than	My brother runs **faster than** my sister.
superlative	the form for comparing three or more: the -est / the most	My sister is **the shortest** of all in my family.
dexterity	the ability to move freely and naturally	the dexterity of your tongue

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
articulate	speak clearly	articulating sentences in English
simplify	make something simple	identify, notify, simplify, verify
refugee	a person who has to leave his or her country because of politics, religion, war, natural disaster, etc.	employee, interviewee, refugee
opponent	a person from the opposite team	kicking the ball into their opponents' goal

Rules and explanations

Four strategies

1. Learn words in context (in sentences): "present" can be a verb or a noun, with different meanings.
2. Try not to translate: "success, succeed, successful, successfully" may work alike in some languages, but not in English.
3. Learn word families and write your own sentences with each form.
4. Read as much as you can, and read aloud.

Where each part of speech goes

- **Nouns** (names of people, places, things, ideas): before a verb (subject); after a verb (object); after a preposition ("On **Facebook**"); after another noun ("the timeline **page**"); after an adjective ("New **features**"); after a determiner ("His **videos**").
- **Verbs** (actions or states): after the subject ("Some people **like** Facebook"); after "to" (to + base verb, called the infinitive: "to **post** their news"); after the causative verbs "make, let, get" ("Parents do not always let their young children **use** the social media"; with "get", add "to": "get them **to use**").
- **Adjectives** (describe nouns): before a noun ("a more **popular** site"); after a linking verb ("Instagram is **full** of images").
- **Adverbs** (describe verbs, adjectives, other adverbs or whole sentences): before or after a verb ("News ... can **quickly** spread. It travels **fast**."); before an adjective ("**very** good news"); before another adverb ("**extremely** frequently"); before or after a whole sentence ("**Unfortunately**, not everyone ... likes my cousin's posts").

Common suffixes

Part of speech	Suffixes (examples)
Noun: people	-er/-or (employer, doctor), -ee (employee), -ist (scientist), -ian (musician), -ant (assistant)

Part of speech	Suffixes (examples)
Noun: things and ideas	-ance/-ence (importance, difference), -cy (democracy), -hood (childhood), -ion/-tion/-sion (decision, communication), -ment (government), -ness (happiness), -ship (friendship), -ty (ability)
Verb	-ate (create), -en (strengthen), -ify (simplify), -ize (realize)
Adjective	-able/-ible (valuable, responsible), -al (social), -ant/-ent (important, different), -ary/-ery (primary), -ful (helpful), -ic (historic), -ing/-ed (interesting/interested), -ish (foolish), -ive (creative), -less (careless), -ly (friendly), -ous (dangerous), -y (healthy)
Adverb	-ly (carefully, happily); many adverbs have no -ly: always, often, very, late, hard, fast, well

There are many exceptions, so look at the context. Not all -ly words are adverbs: "all the **daily** posts" (adjective) / "I do not read everything **daily**" (adverb).

-ed and -ing adjectives

- **-ed** adjectives describe someone's feelings: "The young players were **excited**." "The baby was **frightened** by the loud noise."
- **-ing** adjectives describe the person or thing that produces the feelings: "The soccer game was very **exciting**." "The loud noise ... was **frightening** to the baby."
- "All in all, the game was very **interesting**, and everyone was **interested** except the baby!"

Comparisons

Meaning	Form	Example
the same	the same + noun (+ as)	My hair has the same color as my sister's.
the same	as + adjective/adverb + as	My hair grows as quickly as my sister's.
two things	more (count or noncount), fewer (count), less (noncount) + noun + than	My sister watches fewer soccer games than my brother.
two things	1-syllable adjective/adverb + -er than; 2-syllable adjective in -y: -ier than	My brother runs faster than my sister. My brother is heavier than my sister.
two things	more/less + long adjective (3+ syllables) or -ly adverb + than	My sister swims more slowly than my brother.
three or more	the most + noun	My sister has the most patience of us all.
three or more	the + 1-syllable -est; the + 2-syllable -y adjective: -iest	My sister is the shortest of all in my family.
three or more	the most/the least + long adjective or -ly adverb	My sister is the least athletic in my family.

Irregular forms: good/well - better - best; bad - worse - worst; far - farther/further - farthest/furthest; little - less - least; many/much - more - most.

Common mistakes: "more better" (better), "fastly" (fast), "more slow" (more slowly), "best ways" (the best ways).

> **Note for Arabic speakers**
>
> - Arabic uses one form (the pattern of "akbar") for both "bigger" and "the biggest". English needs two forms: -er / more ... than for two things, and the -est / the most, with "the", for three or more.

Practice

Exercise 1. Find the parts of speech.

(a) Find all the nouns: Personal news was shared through letters, postcards, and face-to-face conversations. That era has long gone.

(b) Find all the verbs: In the 1990s, with the expansion of the Internet, emails gradually replaced many traditional forms of written communication. For example, many companies used emails for internal news and meeting notifications. Personal emails also became popular. They were fast and free.

(c) Find all the adjectives: The social networking sites appeared around early 2000s. ... Anyone who was 13 years and older and had a valid email address in the United States and Canada could establish a Facebook account.

(d) Find all the adverbs: Other social media sites soon quickly followed. ... People are relying more and more on these social media for news and entertainment, especially for personal use. In many workplaces, emails and internal websites (called the Intranets) are probably still the most frequently used means for communication.

Exercise 3. -ed or -ing? A parent posted this after the soccer game.

Example: First of all, the weather was **amazing** (amazing, amazed).

1. I was _____ (surprising, surprised) that the soccer cleats had become a bit too small for him.
2. He'll be so _____ (fascinating, fascinated) to see all the new styles.
3. Imagine how _____ (exciting, excited) and _____ (tiring, tired) everyone was!
4. The kids were _____ (exhausting, exhausted), and the parents, too.
5. For now, let me have a _____ (relaxing, relaxed) time in front of the TV.

Exercise 4. Comparisons. Choose the right word form to compare Android phones and iPhones.

1. Android phones are as _____ as iPhones. a) popular b) more popular c) the most popular
2. The battery life of Android phones is as _____ as that of iPhones. a) longer b) long c) longest
3. Android phones are usually _____ than iPhones. a) cheap b) cheaper c) the cheapest
4. Some people like iPhones even though they are _____. a) expensiver b) more expensive c) the most expensive

5. People who like Android phones enjoy their "open" system. This means that this type of phone is able to work with _____ applications than iPhones. a) many b) more c) the most
6. On the other hand, such "open" system might make the Androids _____. a) less secure b) the least secure c) as secure as
7. As for updates, iPhones provide them _____ than Android phones. a) as frequently as b) more frequently c) frequently
8. In many other areas such as video conferencing and cloud capabilities, both types of phones enjoy _____. a) popular b) more popular c) the same level of popularity
9. Which type is _____, Android or iPhone? It depends on each person's preferences. a) good b) better c) the best
10. Maybe one day in the future, Android phones and iPhones will have _____. a) the same price b) as expensive as c) more expensive

Exercise 6. Choose the word form. Young children learning their heritage language (the language of their family).

Example: Many young children do not receive much **encouragement** (encourage, encouragement) to speak their heritage language at home.

1. Their parents often want them to learn English _____ (good, well) first.
2. Some parents think that the _____ (different, differences) in languages may confuse their children.
3. However, speaking the heritage language in the family can _____ (help, helpful) preserve the home culture and promote communication.
4. It is also a way to show _____ (respect, respectful) for the elderly who usually cannot speak English.
5. For the youngsters, it may be _____ (fun, funny) to learn their heritage language even though it can be very _____ (challenge, challenging).
6. Some young children would rather use their time for other activities, but some others learn their heritage language _____ (happy, happily).

Exercise 7. Word families. Complete the sentences with care, careful, carefully, careless or carelessly. You can use a word more than once.

1. She dressed the baby very _____ before taking him home from the hospital.
2. Be _____ if you are walking alone at night.
3. Did she really _____ about him?
4. The child _____ stepped on a piece of broken glass. Thankfully, he was not hurt.
5. This box is full of glass objects. Handle it with _____.
6. Students often make _____ mistakes in tests. That is why they need to check all the answers _____ before submitting their tests.

More word families (active, dead, live, help, marry, safe): lesson material, Exercise 7. Your tutor can check them.

Exercise 8. Edit a paragraph. In your lesson material, read "A Condo or a House?" (Exercise 8). Find and correct eight more word form errors (not counting the example, best → better).

Speak with your tutor

- "Check my answers to the Pretest, Exercise 2 and the rest of Exercise 7 in the lesson material."
- "For each pair in Exercise 9 (boring/bored, disappointing/disappointed, embarrassing/embarrassed, confusing/confused, surprising/surprised, tiring/tired, fascinating/fascinated), I will say two sentences like 'Lying on the beach is relaxing. I feel relaxed when I lie on the beach.' Correct my word forms."
- "Say a word such as 'decide' or 'create'. I will give you its noun, adjective and adverb forms and use each in a sentence."
- "Compare two universities, two cities or two phones with me. Correct my comparative and superlative forms."

Read aloud

The stress stays on the same syllable in this word family: suc·CESS (noun), suc·CEED (verb), suc·CESS·ful (adjective), suc·CESS·ful·ly (adverb).

- Mark Zuckerberg and his friends launched Facebook suc·CESS·ful·ly.
- The young players were excited /ɪd/ during the soccer game yesterday.
- The parents were amused /d/ by the children's behaviors.
- The baby was frightened /d/ by the loud noise from the soccer field.
- The kids were exhausted /ɪd/, and the parents, too.
- I feel relaxed /t/ when I lie on the beach on a summer evening.

Writing task

Write a comparison paragraph of 150 to 200 words, with at least eight sentences of comparison (Exercise 10). Choose one topic: two or more social media sites, phones, members of your family, vacations you have had, books you have read, or kinds of food.

- Include a title, a topic sentence, supporting sentences with details, and a concluding sentence.
- Use "the same … as", "as … as", two comparatives (-er / more … than), two superlatives (the -est / the most), and at least one -ed and one -ing adjective.

Self-editing checklist:

- Each word is the right part of speech for its position (noun after "a/the", adjective before a noun, adverb to describe a verb).
- Adverbs that describe verbs have the right form (carefully, well, fast).
- -ed adjectives describe feelings; -ing adjectives describe the cause.
- Comparatives have "than"; superlatives have "the".

- No double forms ("more better", "more cheaper").
- I compared two things with -er / more and three or more with the -est / the most.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1 (book) (a) news, letters, postcards, conversations, era (b) replaced, used, became, were (c) social, early, older, valid ("networking", "email" and "Facebook" are nouns used before other nouns.) (d) soon, quickly, more, more, especially, probably, still, most, frequently

Exercise 3 (book)

1. surprised 2. fascinated 3. excited, tired 4. exhausted 5. relaxing

Exercise 4 (book)

1. a) popular 2. b) long 3. b) cheaper 4. b) more expensive 5. b) more 6. a) less secure 7. b) more frequently 8. c) the same level of popularity 9. b) better 10. a) the same price

Exercise 6 (book)

1. well 2. differences 3. help 4. respect 5. fun, challenging 6. happily

Exercise 7 (book)

1. carefully (adverb) 2. careful (adjective) 3. care (verb) 4. carelessly (adverb) 5. care (noun) 6. careless (adjective), carefully (adverb)

Exercise 8

1. many convenient → many conveniences
2. more cheap → cheaper
3. definite larger → definitely larger
4. more comfortably → more comfortable
5. can enjoyment → can enjoy
6. the free → the freedom
7. a difficulty choice → a difficult choice
8. most suitable → more suitable (there are only two choices, a condo or a house, as in the example)

My notes